AEO, GEO and SEO Practitioner Checklist

Every task from first look to long-term care. Use with the Field Guide (part numbers in brackets). 179 items.

0. Scope the job

Agree on what you will do and how success is measured, before you touch anything. [Guide part 4, step 0]

Inputs

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	0.1	Write down the business model	Business potential decides which keywords and prompts matter	Kick-off call; their site; sales deck	What they sell, to whom, where, average deal size, main conversion
☐	0.2	Build the fact sheet	You grade AI answers against it	Primary sources only (own site, filings, official releases); source URL and date per fact	8 to 30 facts, each with a source; client confirms in writing
☐	0.3	Write the one-line positioning and 3 proof points	AI repeats what the web repeats; one clear line wins	Ramonov's pattern: the one thing + proof + proof + proof	Client approves the line
☐	0.4	List 3 to 5 business competitors and 3 search competitors	You benchmark against both	Ask the client; check who ranks and who AI names	Names and domains listed
☐	0.5	Set markets and languages	AI answers change by country	Ask the client	Countries and languages written down
☐	0.6	Collect customer voice	Real questions beat guessed ones	Sales calls, support tickets, reviews (theirs and competitors'), Reddit, forums	At least 20 real questions or complaints in the buyer's words
☐	0.7	Get access	Most fixes and all real data need it	Search Console, GA4, Bing Webmaster Tools, CMS, DNS or Cloudflare, Google Business Profile, social profiles	Each item has an owner and a yes or no
☐	0.8	Agree scope, price, timeline and what you will not do	Protects you and the client	Short proposal or statement of work	Signed or approved in writing
☐	0.9	Map the brand's names (entities)	Each name can win or lose on its own	Main brand, sub-brands, products, named features, own metrics, key people; plus the topics each should own	List saved with topics per name

1. Inspect (the audit)

Where does the brand stand today? Go in gate order: reached, read, trusted, chosen, credited. [Guide part 4, step 1]

1A. Business baseline

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1A.1	Record 12 months of organic traffic	You need the before numbers	Search Console, GA4, or a suite estimate	Trend saved with dates of big changes

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1A.2	List top pages and top queries, branded versus unbranded	Shows what already works and how much demand the brand has	Search Console performance report	Top 20 pages and queries saved
☐	1A.3	Record conversions by channel	Business impact is the real goal	GA4	Conversions per channel per month saved

1B. Crawl and index (technical SEO)

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1B.1	Homepage and key pages return 200	A failing page cannot rank or be cited	Browser, Screaming Frog	No errors on key pages
☐	1B.2	One preferred host	Duplicate versions split signals	Try http, https, www and non-www	All reach one version in one redirect
☐	1B.3	robots.txt allows Googlebot and Bingbot to key pages	Blocked pages are not crawled	Read site.com/robots.txt; Search Console	Key pages allowed
☐	1B.4	No noindex on pages that should rank	Common mistake after a redesign	Screaming Frog; view source; check X-Robots-Tag header	No noindex on key pages
☐	1B.5	XML sitemap exists, listed in robots.txt, submitted	Helps engines find pages	Open the sitemap; Search Console and Bing	Loads, lists key pages, has lastmod, submitted
☐	1B.6	Canonical tags are correct	Tells engines the preferred URL	Screaming Frog	Each page points to itself or the right page
☐	1B.7	No broken internal links	Wastes crawl; frustrates users	Screaming Frog	Internal links return 200
☐	1B.8	No redirect chains	Each hop loses time and signal	Screaming Frog	No internal link passes 2 or more redirects
☐	1B.9	No orphan pages	Pages without internal links are hard to find	Crawl plus sitemap comparison	Every sitemap page has an internal link
☐	1B.10	Key pages within 3 clicks of the homepage	Deep pages get less attention	Crawl depth report	Key pages at depth 3 or less
☐	1B.11	Indexing status checked	Shows what Google actually stored	Search Console, Pages report	No key page excluded without a reason
☐	1B.12	Core Web Vitals on mobile	Slow pages rank, convert and get fetched worse	PageSpeed Insights	LCP 2.5 s or less, INP 200 ms or less, CLS 0.1 or less
☐	1B.13	Mobile friendly	Google indexes the mobile version	PageSpeed Insights; a real phone	Viewport set, text readable, no overlap
☐	1B.14	HTTPS everywhere	Security and trust	Crawl for http links and mixed content	All pages on HTTPS

1C. AI access (technical AEO)

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1C.1	AI search and user bots allowed	They fetch pages at answer time	Read robots.txt for OAI-SearchBot, ChatGPT-User, Claude-SearchBot, Claude-User, PerplexityBot, Perplexity-User	All allowed

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1C.2	Training-bot policy is a choice	Blocking every AI bot also removes the site from live answers	Check GPTBot, ClaudeBot, Google-Extended, CCBot; ask the owner	Rules match what the owner wants
☐	1C.3	No firewall block for AI bots	A 403 or challenge page blocks bots even when robots.txt allows them	curl with a bot user agent; Cloudflare settings; logs for proof	No 403 or challenge for AI bots
☐	1C.4	Cloudflare AI settings checked	Cloudflare can block AI bots by default	Cloudflare dashboard	No block the owner did not choose
☐	1C.5	Main text in raw HTML	ChatGPT's crawler does not run JavaScript	Turn JavaScript off; view source; search for a key sentence	Key text visible without JavaScript
☐	1C.6	No facts hidden in images, PDFs, tabs or pop-ups	Hidden facts are often missed	Read the page as plain text	Key facts are in HTML text
☐	1C.7	Agent readiness scan (optional)	Newer signals; nice to have	isitagentready.com	Score noted; no critical blocker
☐	1C.8	llms.txt (optional)	Not used by major AI companies so far	Open site.com/llms.txt	Noted; never sold as a fix

1D. On-page SEO

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1D.1	One main topic per key page; no cannibalization	Two pages fighting for one keyword both lose	Suite: pages ranking for the same keyword	One page per main keyword
☐	1D.2	Intent match (3 Cs)	Wrong page type will not rank	Search the keyword; compare type, format, angle	Matches most top results
☐	1D.3	Title tags	A strong ranking and click signal	Screaming Frog	Unique, about 60 characters, topic included
☐	1D.4	Meta descriptions	Affects clicks (Google rewrites many)	Screaming Frog	Unique and descriptive
☐	1D.5	URL slugs	Readable URLs help people and bots	Crawl list	Short words with hyphens
☐	1D.6	Heading order	Structure helps people and AI chunking	Screaming Frog; browser extension	One H1; H2 and H3 in order
☐	1D.7	Content gap against the top 3 pages	Missing subtopics lose	Suite content gap or page intersection	Common subtopics covered or listed as tasks
☐	1D.8	Internal links	Pass authority and context	Crawl; site search for related pages	Key pages link to and from related pages
☐	1D.9	Images	Accessibility, image search, speed	Crawl for missing alt; check file size	Alt text, readable names, compressed
☐	1D.10	Readability	Easy text keeps readers and is easy to quote	Hemingway App	About grade 6 to 8
☐	1D.11	Open Graph tags	Better social sharing	View source; sharing debuggers	og:title, og:description, og:image

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1D.12	Schema markup valid	Helps machines read facts (hygiene, not a citation switch)	Rich Results Test; Schema Markup Validator	Valid types for each page type

1E. Content for AI answers

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1E.1	Question headings	Match how buyers ask	Review the 10 to 20 key pages	30% or more of H2 and H3 are real questions
☐	1E.2	Answer first (BLUF)	Humans and AI weigh the start most	Read the first sentences under each heading	First 1 to 2 sentences answer the heading
☐	1E.3	Sections stand alone	AI lifts chunks, not pages	Cover-the-page test	No 'This' or 'As mentioned' openers
☐	1E.4	Entities named	Names give AI something to connect	Search for 'our tool', 'it', 'we'	Brand, products, people named
☐	1E.5	Specific facts, no vague claims	Specific facts get quoted; vague ones do not	Look for numbers, dates, conditions	Claims carry numbers or examples
☐	1E.6	Sources cited	Trust and quotability	Check claims and stats for links	Every stat has a source
☐	1E.7	Named authors with credentials	E-E-A-T	Check bylines and author pages	Real people on key pages
☐	1E.8	Tables in HTML; rows stand alone	Tables are easy to quote	View source	Each row carries its own labels
☐	1E.9	FAQ with real questions	Direct answers to buyer questions	Review key pages	FAQ on key pages
☐	1E.10	Freshness	AI favours recently updated pages	Visible dates; change history	Key pages updated with real changes in 30 to 90 days
☐	1E.11	Page formats present	AI looks for these when buyers compare	Site search	Best-of, vs, alternatives, pricing, FAQ, facts page exist or are listed
☐	1E.12	Original ideas carry the brand name	Unnamed ideas get absorbed without credit	Read key pages	Own frameworks named with the brand

1F. Entity and positioning

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1F.1	Organization (or Person, CollegeOrUniversity, LocalBusiness) schema	Tells machines who the brand is	Rich Results Test	Name, URL, logo, sameAs present
☐	1F.2	sameAs lists only own profiles	Wrong links confuse the entity	Open each sameAs URL	No partner, client or press links
☐	1F.3	About page complete	The main source of identity facts	Read it	Founders, leaders, address, year, what they do
☐	1F.4	One name form	Mixed names split the entity	Titles, schema, text	Same spelling everywhere

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1F.5	No contradictions	AI picks one at random or mixes them	Compare year, phone, email, address across pages	All match
☐	1F.6	Facts or FAQ page	Fills gaps before AI fills them with fiction	Check the site	Answers the fact-sheet questions with specific values
☐	1F.7	People pages	Experts are entities too	Check the site	Founders and experts have bios and profile links
☐	1F.8	Wikidata and Wikipedia status	Knowledge graphs feed AI	Search Wikidata; check the official site link	Status noted; never edit for the client
☐	1F.9	Lookalike brands found	Name clashes steal answers	Search the name; read AI answers	Lookalikes listed with a plan
☐	1F.10	Positioning on the site	Consistency builds the association	Homepage title and meta, About page, schema description	The one-liner or its key words appear
☐	1F.11	Positioning on every profile	Ramonov: repeat it everywhere	LinkedIn headline and company page, X, Instagram, YouTube, directories, podcast bios	Same line everywhere
☐	1F.12	Source-of-truth grid	Shows which source spreads wrong facts	8 to 10 facts x 7 sources; mark wrong cells	Grid built; worst source named

1G. Authority and links

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1G.1	Referring domains and domain rating against the top 3 pages	Links still drive rankings and retrieval	Ahrefs or Semrush	Gap per target keyword known
☐	1G.2	Link quality review	Relevant, authoritative, followed, in-body links count most	Backlink report	Strengths and risks noted
☐	1G.3	Spam or risk check	Bad links can hurt	Look for spikes and unrelated sites	No unexplained spam pattern
☐	1G.4	Unlinked mentions listed	Easy outreach wins	Suite mentions tool; web search	List saved
☐	1G.5	Competitor linkable points	Shows why others earn links	Anchor text report of competing pages	Top reasons listed (stats, lists, tools)

1H. Off-site presence and reputation

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1H.1	Cited domains for the category	These are the sources AI trusts	From the prompt runs (1K)	Top 10 domains; brand present and correct or not
☐	1H.2	Best-of lists and comparisons in the niche	AI leans on them	Search 'best', 'top', 'vs', 'alternatives'	Pages missing the brand listed
☐	1H.3	Review sites	Trust and AI sources	G2, Capterra, Trustpilot, Google, industry sites	Profiles claimed, facts right, reviews answered
☐	1H.4	Reddit and Quora threads	Often cited and part of training data	Search the niche; check which threads rank	Relevant threads listed

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1H.5	YouTube presence	YouTube is heavily cited by Google AI	Search niche topics on YouTube and Google	Brand videos on search topics, or a gap noted
☐	1H.6	News, podcasts, associations, directories	More independent voices	Web search; Listen Notes	Presence noted

1I. Local presence (if relevant)

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1I.1	Google Business Profile	Main local source	Search the business on Google Maps	Right name, address, phone, category, hours, photos; reviews answered
☐	1I.2	Bing Places and Apple Business Connect	Feed Copilot, Bing and Apple Maps	Search each	Claimed and correct
☐	1I.3	NAP consistency on directories	Mismatches confuse engines	BrightLocal or Whitespark; manual search	Same name, address, phone everywhere
☐	1I.4	Location pages	Answer 'near me' and area questions	Site review	One useful page per location

1J. Keyword and prompt research

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1J.1	Seeds and modifiers listed	The start of every keyword list	10 short seeds; commercial, informational and tool modifiers	List saved
☐	1J.2	Keyword ideas pulled	Real searches with volume	Keyword tool, phrase match with modifiers	Idea list with volume
☐	1J.3	Competitor top pages mined	Finds keywords without your seeds	Suite top pages report for search competitors	Extra ideas added
☐	1J.4	Each target passes the tests	Only worthwhile, winnable keywords	Demand, traffic potential, business potential 0 to 3, intent (3 Cs), difficulty (4 questions)	Targets scored
☐	1J.5	AI filter applied	Some keywords no longer give clicks	Search each; full AI answer = mention target, not click target	Click and mention targets split
☐	1J.6	Tool and transactional keywords found	AI cannot replace a tool, so clicks stay	Modifiers: calculator, checker, template, price, buy	List saved
☐	1J.7	Keyword map built	One main keyword per page avoids cannibalization	Sheet: page, main keyword, related keywords	Every key page mapped; new pages listed

1K. AI visibility and Brand Truth baseline

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1K.1	Build the prompt set	A fixed set makes results comparable	Branded, unbranded, comparison, problem, should-not-recommend; from customer voice	40 to 100+ prompts, 40%+ unbranded
☐	1K.2	Run prompts on the main platforms	Each platform differs	Tracker, API or logged-out browser in the right country	AI Overviews, AI Mode, ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Claude covered

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1K.3	Log every run	Proof and repeatability	Sheet: prompt, platform, date, country, search on or off, answer, cited URLs	Every row complete
☐	1K.4	Score visibility and share of voice	Shows the gap against competitors	Named and cited, named only, cited only, not visible	Scores per platform and per topic
☐	1K.5	Brand Truth test	Wrong facts cost trust and sales	About 30 fact questions, 3+ runs, graded against the fact sheet	Accuracy per platform; wrong facts listed
☐	1K.6	A person checks the grades	Machine grades need review	Spot-check 10%+ and every 'Invented'	Reviewed and noted
☐	1K.7	Narrative and tone	Being named wrongly is a gap too	Compare AI wording with the positioning	Narrative gap noted

1L. Measurement setup

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1L.1	Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools verified	Core data	Verify both	Data flowing
☐	1L.2	GA4 AI traffic channel	See AI referrals	Channel group with an AI referrer regex	Channel shows in reports
☐	1L.3	'How did you hear about us?' with AI options	Captures invisible AI influence	Forms, sign-up, checkout	Live and recorded
☐	1L.4	Conversions tracked	Business impact	GA4 key events	Main conversions counted
☐	1L.5	Bing AI Performance report reviewed	Shows Copilot and Bing AI citations	Bing Webmaster Tools	Baseline saved
☐	1L.6	AI bot visits (optional)	Shows what AI reads	Server logs or Cloudflare	Baseline saved

1M. Compliance basics (checks, not legal advice)

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1M.1	Privacy policy and terms linked	Trust and legal basics	Footer	Both present
☐	1M.2	Cookie consent where required	Law in many markets	Visit as a new user	Banner before non-essential cookies where needed
☐	1M.3	Accessibility basics	Users, law and better structure	Page language, alt text, form labels, heading order, contrast, keyboard (WCAG 2.2 AA target)	No basic failures
☐	1M.4	Reviews and testimonials are real	FTC rule on fake reviews	Ask how reviews are gathered	Real; incentives disclosed
☐	1M.5	Paid and affiliate links disclosed	Law and Google rules	Check rel attributes and visible notes	rel=sponsored and a visible disclosure

1N. Competitors

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	1N.1	Light audit of 2 to 3 competitors	Shows what to copy and where to beat them	Repeat 1D to 1K at small scale	'They have X, we do not' list

2. Diagnose

Turn findings into causes and a ranked list. [Guide part 4, step 2]

Causes and priorities

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	2.1	Group findings by gate	Fix the earliest broken gate first	Discovery, retrieval, selection, inclusion, representation	Each finding has a gate
☐	2.2	Fill the six brand gaps	Shows the whole picture	Visibility, narrative, topic, format, web mentions, demand	Each gap has evidence and a severity
☐	2.3	Find root causes	One bad source can cause many wrong answers	Group wrong answers by the source behind them	Root causes named
☐	2.4	Score every fix	Do the most valuable work first	Impact x confidence / effort; Truth Risk Score for wrong facts	Ranked list
☐	2.5	Label each fix Fix, Build or Influence	Different owners and timelines	Ahrefs' split	Every fix labelled
☐	2.6	Place the site on a maturity level (optional)	Clients understand 'you are here, next is there'	Invisible, Crawlable, Structured, Answer-Ready, Agent-Native	Level and next level stated
☐	2.7	Mark quick wins	Early proof builds trust	Pages that rank and need an update; big lists that miss the brand	Quick wins flagged in the list

3. Suggest

Hand over a plan people can act on. [Guide part 4, step 3]

Deliverables

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	3.1	One-page summary	Decision makers read one page	Scores, 3 to 5 findings, 5 top fixes, limits	Fits on one page in plain words
☐	3.2	Full audit with evidence	Proof for every claim	Screenshots, URLs, answers	Every finding has evidence
☐	3.3	Fix list with owners and 'done when'	Clear tasks get done	What, why, who, time, access, done when	Every top fix complete
☐	3.4	30-day and 90-day plan	Sets the order and the rerun date	Own site, then knowledge graph and profiles, then off-site and measurement	Plan with dates and rerun questions
☐	3.5	State the limits	Honest reports keep trust	What was not tested, runs made, answers vary	Limits section present
☐	3.6	List what you need from the client	Unblocks the work	Access, approvals, facts to confirm	List sent

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	3.7	Start the four records	Make every later report provable	Visibility baseline per platform; prompt map; cited-URL log; hypothesis, test and change log	All four exist

4. Implement

Build the fixes in order: unblock, identity, content, new pages, earn, local, measurement. [Guide part 4, step 4]

4A. Unblock (technical)

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4A.1	Allow AI search bots; fix firewall blocks	Opens the door to live answers	robots.txt; Cloudflare rules	Retest passes
☐	4A.2	Fix noindex, canonicals, redirects, broken links	Clean crawl and index	CMS; server; redirect map	Recrawl clean
☐	4A.3	Server-side render key text	Bots without JavaScript can read it	Developer task	Raw HTML shows key text
☐	4A.4	Speed up slow templates	Better rankings and fetching	Caching, image compression, developer fixes	Core Web Vitals pass
☐	4A.5	Submit sitemap; turn on IndexNow if supported	Faster discovery	Search Console, Bing, CMS plugin	Submitted and active

4B. Identity (entity)

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4B.1	Organization or Person schema with correct sameAs	Clear entity	JSON-LD; validate	Valid and only own profiles
☐	4B.2	About and facts pages complete	Official answers to fact questions	Write from the fact sheet	Published and linked
☐	4B.3	Fix contradictions and name forms	One truth everywhere	Edit pages	Recheck passes
☐	4B.4	Align profiles and the positioning line	Consistency across the web	LinkedIn, socials, directories, Google Business Profile	Same line everywhere
☐	4B.5	Prepare Wikidata or Wikipedia requests	Knowledge graphs feed AI	Write the request with sources; follow each site's rules	Request ready; no direct client edits
☐	4B.6	Start a claims register	Keeps facts current	Claim, wording, evidence URL, owner, check date, recheck trigger	Register live with an owner

4C. Rewrite key pages

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4C.1	Rewrite sections with the 5-part pattern	Makes passages quotable	Question heading, answer first, detail, evidence, no broken references	Top 10 pages rewritten
☐	4C.2	Add tables, FAQs and named authors	Easy to quote; E-E-A-T	Edit pages	Live on key pages

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4C.3	Name original frameworks with the brand	Keeps credit	Edit pages; reuse in social and talks	Named and repeated
☐	4C.4	Refresh with real updates	Freshness	New data, examples, dates	Changes logged

4D. Build missing pages

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4D.1	Best-of, vs and alternatives pages	Match buyer comparison questions	Honest tables; state own weaknesses	Published for top competitors
☐	4D.2	Pricing, FAQ, facts, glossary pages	Direct answers	Write from the fact sheet	Published
☐	4D.3	Tools or calculators where they fit	AI cannot replace a tool, so clicks stay	Developer or no-code tool	Live and indexed
☐	4D.4	Case studies with numbers	Proof that AI and buyers trust	Customer, baseline, change, result	At least 3 published
☐	4D.5	Original data or research	The strongest link and citation asset	Survey, benchmark, internal data	One study published with the brand name

4E. Earn mentions (off-site)

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4E.1	Prospect list by reason	Personal pitches at scale	Cited pages, lists missing the brand, unlinked mentions, outdated stats	Segments with 10+ vetted prospects each
☐	4E.2	Vet prospects	Only worthwhile, relevant sites	Live, relevant, still has the issue, has traffic, right language	Vetted list
☐	4E.3	Write one email per segment	Personal without starting from zero	Write to one person, then extract merge fields; subject, reason, why you, pitch, conversation starter; under 120 words	Templates approved
☐	4E.4	Test on a small batch first	Proves the pitch before scaling	10 to 20 prospects per segment	Reply and win rate measured
☐	4E.5	Community answers	Reddit and forums are cited	Honest, disclosed, useful replies	Answers posted where they fit
☐	4E.6	Video plan	YouTube is heavily cited	Search-hit topics; keyword title; description; timestamps; say the keyword	First videos live
☐	4E.7	PR and expert sourcing	Independent voices	Real news only; journalist requests; podcasts	Pitches sent; results logged

4F. Local

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4F.1	Clean up Google Business Profile, Bing Places, Apple	Main local sources	Edit listings	All correct
☐	4F.2	Fix NAP on directories	Consistency	BrightLocal, Whitespark or manual	All match

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4F.3	Review request routine	Reviews drive local trust	After each job or sale; never fake or buy	Routine running

4G. Measurement

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	4G.1	Finish every 1L item	Prove the work	See 1L	All live
☐	4G.2	Keep a change log	Shows what caused what	Date, page, change, reason	Every change logged

5. Measure and report

Did it work? Report ranges and trends. [Guide part 4, step 5]

Monthly report

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	5.1	Rerun the same prompt set	Comparable over time	Same prompts, platforms, country	New scores beside the baseline
☐	5.2	Rerun Brand Truth (quarterly or after big fixes)	Accuracy over time	Same questions, 3+ runs	Accuracy change reported
☐	5.3	SEO numbers	The base still matters	Rankings, organic traffic, branded search, conversions	Trend charts
☐	5.4	AI referrals, bot visits, self-reported discovery	Three views of AI impact	GA4, logs or Cloudflare, forms	All three reported
☐	5.5	What we did, what changed, what is next	Tells the story	Change log plus results	Report sent

6. Maintain

Keep it healthy. [Guide part 4, step 6]

Cadence

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	6.1	Weekly: bots, site errors, AI-cited 404s	Catch breakage fast	robots.txt, site audit, logs; redirect invented URLs that get traffic	Checked weekly
☐	6.2	Monthly: visibility rerun, 2 to 3 page refreshes, mentions, follow-ups, report	Steady progress	See step 5	Done monthly
☐	6.3	Quarterly: full audit, competitor audit, Brand Truth rerun	Catch bigger shifts	Repeat steps 1 to 3	Done quarterly
☐	6.4	On any change: update facts page, schema, profiles, claims register	Stop new wrong facts	Same week as the change	Updated within a week

7. Improve

Grow beyond the fixes. [Guide part 4, step 7]

Growth

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	7.1	Expand topic coverage (fan-out)	Win more of the sub-questions	Map sub-questions of top prompts	New sections or pages each month
☐	7.2	Yearly original research	Links, citations, brand association	Survey or benchmark with the brand name	Published
☐	7.3	Video and community programs	Formats AI cites	Monthly plan	Running
☐	7.4	Experiments with a hypothesis log	Learn what works for this brand	Change one thing; compare on the same prompts	Results logged
☐	7.5	Review platform mix	Buyers move between tools	Ask customers; check referrals	Priorities updated
☐	7.6	Buyer journey study (advanced)	Shows where the brand drops out before purchase	Prompts per stage (problem, search, shortlist, compare, approve) and buyer role	Drop-off stage found and fixed

8. Your own practice

Build yourself as an expert. [Guide parts 7 and 8]

Skills and business

	#	TASK	WHY	HOW	DONE WHEN
☐	8.1	Finish the three Ahrefs courses	The base method	Ahrefs Academy	Done; AEO exam passed
☐	8.2	One full case study with numbers	Proof wins clients	Own site or a willing client	Before and after published
☐	8.3	Templates ready	Speed and quality	Audit, one-page summary, fix list, monthly report, outreach email	All saved
☐	8.4	SOPs for repeat tasks	Systems beat heroics	Write as you work	SOP per phase
☐	8.5	First automations	Bridge to marketing automation	Prompt runs, monthly report, 404 alerts in n8n	Three automations live
☐	8.6	Packages and prices	Easy to buy	Snapshot, audit, sprint, retainer	Written down
☐	8.7	Stay current	AI search changes monthly	Ahrefs blog, Google Search Central, vendor docs; recheck figures	Monthly review habit